

10.3 Windows Complete PC Backup And Restore

The Ultimate, Business, and Enterprise versions of Vista also offer “Complete PC Backup and Restore,” which essentially creates a disk image of your entire computer that can then be saved on a hard drive, on network storage, or burnt to DVD. The Complete PC restore can also be initiated from the Windows Vista installation disc in the event of PC failure. While file restore is useful in cases of file loss and data corruption, this particular feature is most useful for disaster recovery when your PC malfunctions. Complete PC Backup and Restore is capable of restoring your entire PC environment, including the operating system, installed programs, user settings, and data files.

You should create an image of your hard drive through this program once you have completed the initial installation of the operating system and installed your favourite applications. Making an image such as this after every six months, or after you have made major changes to your system, is also good practice.

To start a Complete PC Backup, go to the Start Menu, type “ba r” in the Search box and launch the Backup and Restore Center. Click on the “Back up computer” button here to start the process and trigger the Wizard. Start by choosing an appropriate backup medium—note that Vista will suggest a backup media based upon a scan of your system. If you are backing up to optical discs, keep a few in hand, or else you can choose to backup the image to a network or external drive. Once you have selected the medium to save your computer’s image to, press Next. If you have multiple disks or partitions on your system, you will be prompted to select the ones you wish to be backed up. You will then be taken to the confirmation screen which will summarise the process for you: the disks and partitions that will be backed up and how many DVDs will be required, for example. Press “Start backup” to start the process.

In the event that your system has been corrupted beyond